



ROMANIA

Capital city: Bucharest**Area:** 91,699 sq miles
(237,500 sq km)**Population:** 22,300,000**Official language:**
Romanian**Major religions:** Christian
85%, other 15%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Leu**Adult literacy rate:** 97%**Life expectancy:** 70 years**People per doctor:** 526**Televisions:** 223 per 1,000
people

ROMANIA

ONCE THE FRONTIER OF THE ROMAN EMPIRE, Romania is one of the largest countries in Europe. The Carpathian Mountains form an arc across the country, curving around the region of Transylvania. Elsewhere the land is rich and fertile. Romania became independent from Turkey in 1878, but its borders have been redrawn several times as a result of war. A revolution in 1989 overthrew a harsh communist government and today Romania is struggling to improve the life of its people. Although Romanians can now travel and worship in freedom, there is high unemployment and food has become more expensive.

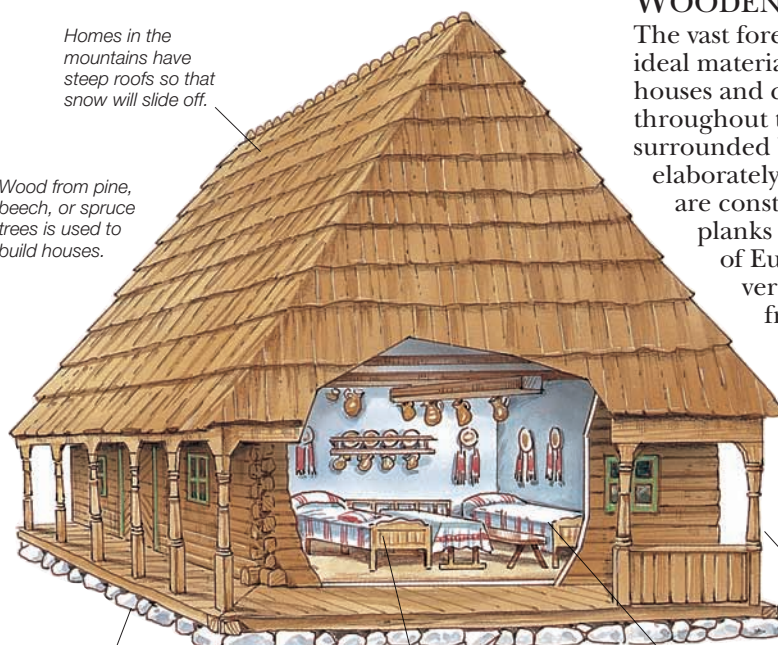


POLITICS

From 1965 until his overthrow and execution in 1989, communist leader Nicolae Ceaucescu ruled Romania. During his brutal dictatorship, he tried to boost the population by encouraging women to have large families. Many people could not afford to keep their babies. The plight of Romanian orphans attracted international attention and many were adopted abroad.

WOODEN BUILDINGS

The vast forests of Romania provide an ideal material for building, and wooden houses and churches are found throughout the country. Many are surrounded by wooden fences and elaborately carved gateways. The walls are constructed using horizontal planks of wood, unlike in the rest of Europe, where they are placed vertically. House styles vary from one region to another. The steep-roofed home shown here is from a snowy area in the Carpathian Mountains; homes in wine-growing areas would have large cellars to store wine and fruit from the orchards.



Homes in the mountains have steep roofs so that snow will slide off.

Wood from pine, beech, or spruce trees is used to build houses.

Houses are built on foundations of local stone to prevent the wood from rotting.

Rooms are decorated with carved wooden furniture and brightly painted plates.

Columns may be hand-carved in a local design.

Bedspreads are embroidered with traditional designs.



FOREIGN ORDERS

In order to modernize old industries and create new jobs, foreign companies are being encouraged to set up business in Romania. France, Spain, Italy, the US, and South Korea all now have manufacturing plants in or near Bucharest.

PEOPLE OF ROMANIA

Romania is home to many peoples, with Hungarians and Germans sharing the land with native Romanians. Ukrainians and Turks settled areas near the Black Sea coast, now popular as vacation destinations. In the past, people lived and worked on the land, but with the growth of industry the majority now live in Bucharest, the capital, and other towns and cities.



ROMA POPULATIONS

Despite their name, the 500,000 Roma who live in Romania belong to a different ethnic group from the rest of the population. Although they used to live as nomads, they are now mostly settled on the outskirts of towns.



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